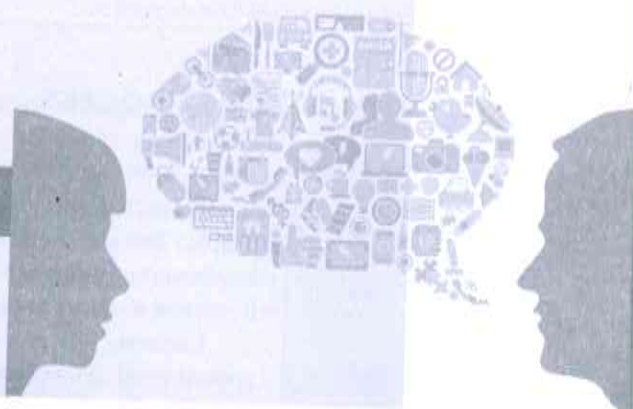


5

CHAPTER



The Listening Process

Listening is the process of creating meaning in the speaker.

—Michael Rost

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understanding the process of listening
- Learning to differentiate between hearing and listening
- Analysing the differences between effective and ineffective listening
- Knowing how to differentiate between active and passive listening
- Identifying barriers to listening
- Understanding listening comprehension skills

5.1 THE LISTENING PROCESS

"You are not listening to me," says the teacher. "Sir, I am listening to you," the student replies. "No, you are not," the teacher emphatically says. The problem is simple. The student is not able to focus 100% on what the teacher is speaking, and the teacher is able to sense it. It is important to be a good listener and to be perceived as one.

Effective listening involves not only recognising unit boundaries phonologically, but also the recognition of false starts, pauses, hesitations, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns.

It is important to be a good listener and to be perceived as one.

Listening is a process of receiving and interpreting the spoken word. It involves recognising what is said and comprehending the matter, i.e., understanding the main and subsidiary points as well as the links between the different parts of speech. This means that effective listening involves not only recognising unit boundaries phonologically, but also the recognition of false starts, pauses, hesitations, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns. While receiving and interpreting the spoken word, the listener is concerned with four factors, i.e., sensing, message decoding or interpreting, evaluating and response, as illustrated in Fig. 5.1.

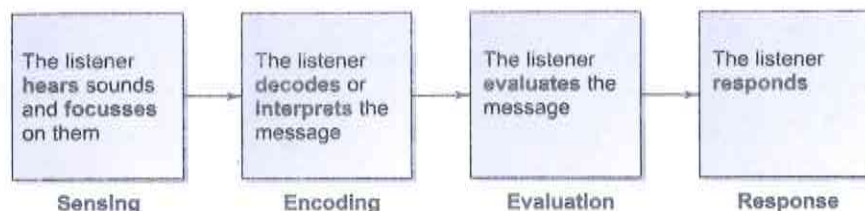


Fig. 5.1 The Listening Process

Listening begins with physical hearing of the message and taking note of it. Sensing is, thus, the first step of the listening process. You hear sounds and concentrate on them in order to receive the message. You recognise unit boundaries phonologically as it is important for you to recognise phonological differences. Once you are able to recognise the sound patterns, you have to decode and interpret the message.

Decoding or interpreting in listening refers to the process of changing the coded message into information. It involves understanding the spoken language. Although interpretation of a verbal message may be influenced by your social, cultural, educational, professional, and intellectual frames of reference, verbal messages use a common language code, which can be easily decoded because if the message cannot be decoded or understood, communication fails. For example, if you do not understand French, you can not decode a message encoded in French. The process of message decoding in listening also involves the recognition of false starts, pauses, hesitations, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns.

In order to evaluate a verbal message correctly, facts have to be separated from opinions, relevant information from irrelevant information, examples from ideas, and explicit information from implicit information.

We should be aware of our own prejudices and biases so that we avoid making wrong conclusions.

After the message has been decoded and interpreted, its significance is evaluated and appropriate conclusions are drawn from it. In order to evaluate a verbal message correctly, facts have to be separated from opinions, relevant information from irrelevant information, examples from ideas, and explicit information from implicit information. The intention and attitude of the speaker also have to be analyzed and

understood. When we listen, we have to construct a parallel message based on the sound clues received from the speaker. We should be aware of our own prejudices and biases so that we avoid making wrong conclusions.

Response is the action or reaction of the listener to the message. It is the last stage of listening. If the message has been analysed, interpreted, and evaluated correctly, the response will be appropriate. The response makes the communication more effective as it clarifies the message and helps the speaker to know whether the message has been understood or not.

The response makes the communication more effective as it clarifies the message and helps the speaker to know whether the message has been understood or not.

2 HEARING VERSUS LISTENING

A clear distinction should be made between listening and hearing. Hearing happens automatically as it is an involuntary physical act. It does not require the conscious involvement of the listener. When you move on a highway platform, you hear several voices. You do not listen to them. Suddenly there is an announcement on a public speaker and we listen to it. When we listen, we pay conscious attention to what is being said.

Table 5.1 summarises the differences between listening and hearing.

TABLE 5.1 Differences Between Listening and Hearing

<i>Listening</i>	<i>Hearing</i>
• Voluntary • Requires conscious efforts • Active process • The listener plays a very active part • A two-way interactive process engaging the speaker and the listener	• Involuntary • Happens automatically • Passive process • The listener plays a passive part • A one-way process

Progress Check 1

Which of the following statements about the process of listening are false?

- The process of decoding in listening takes place as soon as the message reaches the receiver.
- Listening refers to the accurate perception of what is being said.
- Listening requires no special effort by the listener.
- Effective listening involves only recognising unit boundaries phonologically.
- Response is the action or reaction of the listener to the message.
- Listening involves perceiving and interpreting the sounds correctly, and understanding the implied meaning.
- Hearing happens automatically as it is an involuntary physical act.
- Listening is a two-way interactive process engaging the speaker and the listener.
- While receiving and interpreting the spoken word, the listener is not concerned with message decoding.
- Decoding in listening refers to the process of changing the coded message into information.

5.3 TYPES OF LISTENING

As illustrated in Table 5.2, listening may be classified into the following six types on the basis of purpose and output:

1. Superficial listening
2. Appreciative listening
3. Focused listening
4. Evaluative listening
5. Attentive listening
6. Empathetic listening

TABLE 5.2 Types of Listening

<i>Types</i>	<i>Characteristics</i>
Superficial listening	The listener has little awareness of the content of the verbal message.
Appreciative listening	The purpose of listening is to derive pleasure.
Focused listening	The purpose is to get some specific information.
Evaluative listening	The purpose is to evaluate the oral message, commentary and develop a line of thought.
Attentive listening	It is interactive and productive, facilitating proper interaction and more effective listener-speaker relationships.
Empathetic listening	It involves listening to the speaker's feelings, emotions, and state of mind.

5.3.1 Superficial Listening

In this type of listening, the listener has little awareness of the content (what is being said). The output in this type of listening is zero because the listener tends to ignore the message, and is not able to concentrate on the theme, main points, and supporting details of the message.

5.3.2 Appreciative Listening

The main purpose of appreciative listening is to get enjoyment and pleasure. Examples include listening to recordings of songs, entertaining stories, jokes, anecdotes, and so on. The output may be taking part in the entertainment process. For example, a music lover may listen to the latest hit, pick up the chorus and tune, and try to sing along.

5.3.3 Focused Listening

Focused listening involves listening for specific information. The main purpose is to get some specific information that might be used to take a decision. This is the most common type of listening that we practice in non-formal oral communicative situations. Examples include listening to the radio, watching and listening to television programmes, listening to railway and airport announcements, and so on.

Focused listening is the most common type of listening that we practice in non-formal oral communicative situations.

5.3.4 Evaluative Listening

Evaluative listening involves evaluation of the oral message or commentary and developing a line of thought. The listener interprets and analyses what he or she listens to in order to understand both the explicit as well as implicit meaning of the oral message. It may also involve matching topics against one's own interests, and making mental notes of the important points. Thus, the main purpose of evaluative listening is to evaluate the content of the oral message to select appropriate information. The output could be an oral response, or summarising and recalling information at a later stage. Examples include listening to structured talks, classroom lectures, workshops, seminars, and so forth.

The listener interprets and analyses what he or she listens to in order to understand both the explicit as well as implicit meaning of the oral message.

5.3.5 Attentive Listening

Attentive listening demands the complete attention of the listener. It is basically active and intelligent listening in situations such as group discussions, meetings, job interviews, and so on. The listener pays attention to all parts of the message, i.e., the central idea, main points, supporting details, examples, and illustrations. There is no 'selective dismissal' of any part of the oral message.

Attentive listening demands the complete attention of the listener.

As attentive listening is interactive and productive, facilitating proper interaction and more effective listener-speaker relationships, it requires conscious effort on the part of the listener and demands concentration, involvement, and responsibility. Some other examples of attentive listening include listening to administrative instructions, formal conversational interaction, suggestions, requests, important telephone calls, and so on.

5.3.6 Empathetic Listening

Empathetic listening is listening not only to what the speaker is saying but also to how he/she is saying, i.e., his/her feelings, emotions, and state of mind. The listener has to understand and respond to the affective signals that the speaker might make and has to be alert to the speaker's implied meaning, intention, and attitude. Moreover, he/she has to understand and interpret non-verbal clues and the body language of the speaker.

Empathetic listening is listening not only to what the speaker is saying but also to how he/she is saying it.

Progress Check 2

1. Match List I with List II and select the correct answer from the given options:

LIST I

- (1) Superficial listening
- (2) Appreciative listening
- (3) Focused listening
- (4) Evaluative listening
- (5) Attentive listening
- (6) Empathetic listening

LIST II

- (a) Listening to a musical programme
- (b) Listening to a frustrated colleague
- (c) Listening to a speaker during a group discussion
- (d) Listening to a business presentation
- (e) Listening to a news report
- (f) listening to a radio programme while reading a newspaper

OPTIONS

- (i) 1 - b, 2 - a, 3 - e, 4 - d, 5 - c, 6 - f
 (ii) 1 - f, 2 - a, 3 - d, 4 - c, 5 - c, 6 - b
 (iii) 1 - f, 2 - a, 3 - e, 4 - d, 5 - c, 6 - b
 (iv) 1 - f, 2 - a, 3 - c, 4 - e, 5 - d, 6 - b

We listen to different kinds of oral messages for different purposes.

5.4 LISTENING WITH A PURPOSE

The above description of different types of listening clearly indicates that the most important thing to settle initially is simply why a particular oral message is being listened to. Listening to classical music is quite different from listening to a lecture. People may listen for relaxation or entertainment, for getting information, for solving problems, or for discussion at a later stage. They listen to different kinds of oral messages for different purposes. Is it serious listening or light listening? What matters most is the overall purpose of listening.

Although the basic purpose of listening is to receive information from various sources, there can be different purposes in listening. One may listen to:

- Get an introductory idea of an oral message
- Understand the main points of a lecture
- Discover the speaker's ideas during a conversation
- Understand differing viewpoints in order to contribute to a discussion
- Aim a broad understanding of the subject matter of a seminar
- Obtain specific information
- Understand new changes and developments in a particular field
- Broaden one's outlook and understanding
- Seek evidence for one's own points of view

In order to achieve the above listening purposes, one needs to understand the differences between effective and ineffective listening. Study Table 5.3 to understand these differences:

TABLE 5.3 Difference Between effective and Ineffective Listening

<i>Effective Listening</i>	<i>Ineffective Listening</i>
The listener is aware of a clear specific purpose of listening and he/she is motivated to listen.	The listener has no clear purpose and he/she has no motivation to listen to the speaker.
The listener understands the language of the speaker.	The listener finds it difficult to understand the language of the speaker.
The content of the oral message is accessible to the listener because of his/her familiarity with the content.	The content is unfamiliar and far removed from the listener's knowledge and experience.
The listener pays attention to a person's speech and concentrates on the theme, main points, and supporting details of the message.	The listener does not pay attention to a person's speech and is not able to concentrate on the theme, main points, and supporting details of the message.

(Contd.)

As the listener concentrates on the important parts of the message, he/she thinks ahead, hypothesises, and predicts.

The listener asks questions for clarifications to ensure that he/she has understood the speaker.

The listener has and uses background information to help understand the lecture or speech.

The listener interprets and analyses while he/she listens.

The listener is able to use different strategies for different kinds of oral discourses.

The listener does not think ahead as he/she pays the same amount of attention to all parts of the message.

The listener does not question the speaker regardless of whether he/she has heard accurately or not.

The listener does not have or does not use background information.

The listener does not interpret and analyse while he/she listens.

The listener is not able to use different strategies for different kinds of oral discourses.

Progress Check 3

1. Which of the following is not a clear aspect of effective listening?

- (a) predicting and hypothesising
- (b) lack of motivation to listen
- (c) use of background information
- (d) comprehensible language
- (e) interpreting and analysing the message
- (f) paying the same amount of attention to all parts of the verbal message
- (g) use of similar strategies for different kinds of oral discourses
- (h) asking clarifying questions
- (i) inaccessible and unfamiliar content
- (j) a clear specific purpose of listening
- (k) concentration on the core information
- (l) lack of interest in the verbal message

2. Analyse the following situations and identify effective and ineffective listeners:

- (a) Anita is taking part in a meeting. She is carefully listening to each member of the team. While listening to them, she is interpreting and analysing what they are speaking. She is trying to understand both explicit as well as implicit meaning of the verbal messages in order to respond to their views.

Effective/Ineffective

- (b) John is listening to a lecture on software technology. As he is a student of English literature, he is not interested in the subject. Moreover, he is feeling sleepy and is listening in an unconscious manner without paying any attention to what he is listening.

Effective/Ineffective

- (c) Rajesh is listening to a business presentation. However, his mind is busy thinking about the questions that he will ask. He wants to show the audience that he knows much more than the speaker. So, he is not able to pay attention to the content or the visual aids that the speaker is using.

Effective/Ineffective

- (d) Serjesh is taking part in a group discussion on the topic "Implementation of flexitime in the banking sector". He is listening to the first speaker, who is a bit nervous. Serjesh is encouraging her to express her ideas clearly and is giving non-verbal signals to indicate comprehension. She stops to

find words and he gives her words by saying, "I hope you are trying to say that flexitime is not a good idea for the banking sector".

Effective/Ineffective

- (e) Kavita is listening to the teacher, who is explaining different steps of computer programming. She is not taking any interest in the lecture as she is amused at the hair style of the teacher and is wondering how he will look without any hair.

Effective/Ineffective

- (f) Mohan is listening to a talk on the Indian economy. Although he is a student of mechanical engineering, he is trying to understand the lecture by concentrating on the main points and supporting details. He finds the visuals used by the speaker very interesting and helpful.

Effective/Ineffective

- (g) Neha is taking part in a selection G.D. She is listening to the second speaker, who is using abstract phrases and expressions. She tries to infer the meaning of unfamiliar words from contextual clues. She pays attention to the speaker's intention, and is trying to understand and interpret non-verbal clues and body language of the speaker.

Effective/Ineffective

5.5 BARRIERS TO LISTENING

As listening is a complex process, it is desirable to take care of the barriers that may hamper the smooth flow of oral communication. Awareness of these barriers can help the listener adopt effective strategies to avoid them. The barriers to the listening process may emanate from either the speaker, listener, or the circumstances of communication. In oral communicative situations, any interference or noise that interferes with the listening process can create misunderstanding and confusion and may sometimes lead to communication breakdown.

Barriers to listening could be physical, psychological, linguistic, or cultural (Table 5.4).

The barriers to the listening process may emanate either from the speaker, listener, or from the circumstances of communication.

TABLE 5.4 Barriers to Listening

<i>Physical Barriers</i>	<i>Psychological Barriers</i>	<i>Linguistic Barriers</i>	<i>Cultural Barriers</i>
• Noise • Physical discomfort • Physical distractions • distance	• Emotional disturbance • Anxiety • Over arousal of emotions	• Improper message decoding • Ambiguous language • Jargon	• Cultural differences • Different values • Different social norms

5.5.1 Physical Barriers

Physical distractions and disturbances can easily disrupt the process of listening. Barriers to listening could be noise, physical discomfort, or any physical factor. Physical noise refers to any sound that disrupts the listening process. For example, a person is talking on his/her mobile phone and a queer shrilling sound

disturbs the transmission. When a person tries to talk to someone on a running train, bus, or in a crowded market, several distractions in the surroundings disrupt the listening process. In order to avoid physical noise during the process of listening, we have to ensure that all channels are free from noise during the time of communication.

Physical discomfort can also easily disrupt the listening process because one cannot be a good listener if one is feeling uncomfortable. For instance, if a person is listening to a business presentation in a conference room but the room temperature is very high and there is no air-conditioner, his/her discomfort due to high room temperature may distract his/her attention and he/she may not be able to focus on the presentation. This can lead to poor comprehension. It is, therefore, important that you avoid any discomfort before beginning to listen to someone.

In order to ensure a comfortable listening without physical disturbances, we should take care of the following points:

- Ensure that there is no distracting noise from outside. Close the door if there is some disturbing noise from outside.
- If it is a very important communicative situation like a meeting or conference, mobile phones should be switched off.
- Be sure that the infrastructure, such as seating arrangement, is comfortable.
- As distance can sometimes become a barrier to effective listening, we should sit at a proper place, maintaining appropriate distance.
- Be comfortable and at ease.

5.5.2 Psychological Barriers

Perhaps some of the most common barriers to listening result from the listener's disturbed state of mind, i.e., they are psychological in nature. As listening is a purposeful activity, any psychological or emotional turbulence or disturbance can prove to be a barrier to effective listening because it leads to lack of interest and concentration. Feelings of anger, frustration, sadness, anxiety, or fear influence our reception and receptivity to others' ideas. Over arousal of emotions may adversely affect the listeners ability to decode an oral message, and he or she may find it difficult to concentrate on what the speaker is saying.

Thus, one must ensure that one is in a normal state of mind before one takes part in a communicative interaction. The listener should be tension-free and should not upset himself/herself by too much thinking and speculation. For example, if a person has to face a job interview and he is too nervous, he/she should avoid such feelings of discomfort. Whatever may be the purpose of listening, the listener needs to concentrate on the content of the oral message if he/she wants to take an active part in the communication process.

As listening is a purposeful activity, any psychological or emotional turbulence or disturbance can prove to be a barrier to effective listening because it leads to lack of interest and concentration.

5.5.3 Linguistic Barriers

Improper message decoding during listening is the recurrent barrier in the process of oral communication. Since the message is decoded incorrectly by the listener, it may lead to confusion and misunderstanding. While decoding an oral message, the listener should concentrate on the linguistic code. If he/she listens to something in a

Improper message decoding during listening is the recurrent barrier in the process of oral communication.

language or dialect that he/she is not able to follow, a communication breakdown will definitely occur. For example, if he/she does not understand French properly, he/she may not understand a lecture in French.

In order to avoid linguistic barriers, the following points should be noted:

- Ensure that the speaker is using a language that the listener understands.
- Sometimes, the speaker may use difficult words, jargon, technical terminology, or unclear phrases. The listener should feel free to ask for clarifications. No good speaker will mind it.
- If the speaker uses ambiguous language open to several interpretations, the listener should ask the speaker to clarify and explain.
- When the listener is in doubt, he/she should ask questions.

5.5.4 Cultural Barriers

If the speaker and listener belong to different cultures and share different values, listening could become a difficult process. In oral communication, it is the listener who assigns meaning to message cues and meanings are assigned in terms of the listener's frame of reference. This interpretation of meaning can create misunderstandings during intercultural communication due to differences in norms and values. Our values are our personal guides to thought and behaviour, and exert a strong influence on us.

In order to avoid cultural barriers during listening, a listener should be sensitive to cultural differences and take into account the values of the speaker while interpreting an oral message. The listener's weakness in viewing others within his/her own cultural frame of reference may lead to confusion and misunderstanding. The moment he/she interprets others' point of view from his/her angle, he/she allows his/her preconceived notions and prejudices to start working for him/her. His/her frame of reference is individual to him/her as it is based on his/her experiences, exposure, education, personality, and several other elements peculiar to him/her. In order to avoid communication failure, the listener has to be sensitive to this fact and try to put himself/herself in the other person's position.

A listener should be sensitive to cultural differences and take into account the values of the speaker while interpreting an oral message.

Progress Check 4

1. Which of the following steps to overcome barriers to listening may not be effective:

- (a) Avoiding any physical discomfort before listening to someone.
- (b) Ensuring that all channels are free of noise during the time of communication.
- (c) While listening to a lecture or talk, the listener sits at a proper place and maintains appropriate distance.
- (d) If the speaker uses ambiguous language open to several interpretations, the listener does not ask the speaker to clarify and explain.
- (e) The listener ensures that he is in a normal state of mind before taking part in a communicative interaction.
- (f) The listener tries to be tension-free and avoids upsetting himself by too much thinking and speculation while listening to a presentation.
- (g) Whatever may be the purpose of listening, the listener concentrates on the content of the oral message in order to take an active part in the communication process.

- (h) If the speaker uses difficult words, jargon, technical terminology, or unclear phrases, the listener does not disturb the speaker by asking questions for clarifications.
 - (i) The listener is sensitive to cultural differences and takes into account the values of the speaker while interpreting an oral message in order to avoid cultural barriers during listening.
 - (j) The listener is sensitive to the fact that his/her frame of reference is individual to him/her as it is based on his/her experiences, exposure, education, personality, and several other elements peculiar to him/her.
 - (k) The listener is aware of his/her prejudices and biases.
 - (l) In order to avoid communication failure, the listener tries to put himself/herself in the other person's position.
-

Exercise

1. Answer the following questions briefly:

- (a) What is listening?
- (b) What are the different steps involved in the process of listening?
- (c) How is hearing different from listening?
- (d) How is effective listening different from ineffective listening?
- (e) What are barriers to listening? What steps should you take to overcome them?
- (f) What are the different types of listening?

2. Ask a friend to read the following speech and answer the questions that follow. Do not read yourself.

Ladies and gentlemen,

I would like to talk about something that may not sound very interesting but it is definitely very important. Well, I'll say something about forests. To be precise, I'd throw some light on two aspects of forests, i.e., significance of forests and their excessive exploitation.

Forests provide several products of daily use, such as food, timber, firewood, wood pulp, forage and fibre, apart from being a vast storehouse of medicinal plants that are yet to be fully explored and exploited. Forests are potent sources of many industrial raw materials. The greatest significance of forests, however, lies in their critical role in maintaining ecological processes and life support systems.

According to official records our country has an area of 633.4 lakh hectares notified as forests, which represents 19.27 per cent of the total geographic area. The National Forest Policy of 1952 recommends that 33 per cent of the land area of the country should be under forests. Contrary to this guideline, however, forests have been under increasing assault since independence. Excessive exploitation of forests and overgrazing have seriously decimated our forest resources.

QUESTIONS

- 1. What is the central idea of the speech?
- 2. What is the attitude of the speaker towards forests?
- 3. What do the forests provide?
- 4. What is their significance according to the speaker?
- 5. What percentage of the geographic area do our forests comprise?
- 6. What is the recommendation of the National Forest Policy of 1952?

7. What is the direct result of excessive exploitation of forests and overgrazing?
8. What conclusion can you draw from this speech?

Key to Progress Check

Progress Check 1

1. c, d and i

Progress Check 2

1. (iii) 1 - f, 2 - a, 3 - e, 4 - d, 5 - c, 6 - b

Progress Check 3

1. b, f, g, i, and l
2. **Effective listeners** Anita, Serjesh, Mohan, Neha
Ineffective listeners John, Rajesh, Kavita

Progress Check 4

1. (d) and (h)

6

CHAPTER



Improving Listening Comprehension

The most important thing in communication is hearing what isn't said.

—Peter Drucker

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Acquiring listening skills
- Learning to identify different aspects of effective listening
- Knowing the 10 thumb rules for good listening
- Grasping techniques for active listening
- Knowing strategies for listening in conversational interaction
- Understanding techniques for listening to structured talks
- Knowing how to become an effective team listener
- Grasping techniques for note taking

6.1 LISTENING COMPREHENSION

Comprehension is the act of understanding or the power of the mind to understand. Listening comprehension is the act of understanding an oral message. As a professional, you have to achieve the ability to comprehend material delivered at relatively fast speed and understand spoken material in standard Indian English, British English or American English. You need intelligent listening skills in situations such as an interview in which you are a candidate, or a group discussion, or a meeting in which you are a participant.

Listening comprehension is an act of understanding an oral message.

Scanning is the ability to locate specific information in a conversation, speech, or presentation whereas prediction is guessing information.

Being a complex process that involves perceiving and interpreting the sounds correctly as well as understanding the explicit and implied meaning of the oral message, listening comprehension includes several skills and sub-skills. These skills include scanning, prediction, speech decoding, comprehending, and oral discourse analysis. The first two skills are similar to scanning and prediction in reading comprehension. Scanning is the ability to locate specific information in a conversation, speech, or presentation whereas prediction is guessing information. The three other skills need some explanation.

6.1.1 Speech Decoding

Speech decoding is integral to listening comprehension. It involves sound perception and recognition, word recognition, and accent recognition.

Sound Perception and Recognition

Decoding of verbal messages requires the ability to perceive and recognise speech sounds and sound patterns accurately as well as the ability to recognise the way sounds combine to form syllables and utterances. The listener has to be attentive to the sounds that he/she hears because any lapse or mistake may lead to miscommunication and misunderstanding. Moreover, a large number of competing sounds from the environment may interfere with concentration and if the listener is not careful, he/she may not perceive sounds accurately.

The listener has to be attentive to the sounds that he/she hears because any lapse or mistake may lead to miscommunication and misunderstanding.

Word Recognition

Speech decoding during listening also involves the ability to recognise words accurately, understand definitions of the words and phrases being used, recognise the way words are used in context, and identify discourse markers and attention signals.

Accent Recognition

In order to decode a verbal message, the listener has to recognise stress and intonation patterns. In addition, he/she needs to identify pauses, false starts, hesitations, and turn-taking in a conversation, discussion, or other transactions involving more than one speaker.

6.1.2 Comprehending

Comprehending a verbal message involves the ability to:

- Identify the central theme, main ideas, and supporting details
- Concentrate and understand long speeches
- Identify the level of formality
- Deduce incomplete information
- Decode unfamiliar vocabulary

6.1.3 Oral Discourse Analysis

Oral discourse analysis is the process of identifying relationships among different units within the speech or oral message. It includes critical skills, attitude analysis, and inferential skills.

Critical Skills

When you listen to a structured talk, speech, or presentation, you need to analyse it in order to distinguish between relevant and irrelevant information, factual and non-factual information, examples and ideas, and so on. Critical skills are, thus, essential to effective listening comprehension.

Oral discourse analysis is the process of identifying relationships among different units within the speech or oral message.

Attitude Analysis

You may have to analyse a verbal message in order to understand the speaker's attitude to you and the topic under discussion. This is more important in meetings, discussions, and conferences. Attitude analysis includes the following skills:

- Identifying a speaker's attitude
- Understanding the speaker's attitude
- Evaluating a speaker's attitude

Inferential Skills

Effective listening comprehension involves understanding not only the explicit meaning of a verbal message but also the implicit meaning because the speaker may not speak everything explicitly and clearly. Thus, the listener may have to analyse a verbal message in order to draw inferences and conclusions. This may involve interpreting the non-verbal clues and body language of the speaker.

Progress Check 1

1. Complete the following table in the light of the above discussion about listening comprehension skills:

Listening comprehension skills

Literal skills

.Sound recognition

- _____
- _____

Word recognition

- Recognising words accurately

- _____
- _____
- _____

Accent recognition

- _____

Scanning

- _____

Prediction

- _____

Comprehending

- Identifying theme or central idea

- _____

- _____

Critical and
analytical skills

Critical skills

Distinguishing between

- Facts and opinions

- _____

- _____

- _____

Attitude analysis

- _____

- _____

- _____

Inferential skills

- _____

6.2 EFFECTIVE LISTENING STRATEGIES

Complete comprehension of an oral message is more challenging than reading. A text can be reread if there is any problem in comprehension but there is no such scope in listening. As listening is a major aspect of academic and professional interaction, mastering the art of effective listening is essential. Moreover, listening is a communication opportunity and taking advantage of such opportunities makes a person a dedicated professional.

Complete comprehension of an oral message is more challenging than reading.

Most students who do not have a systematic approach to listening suffer from lack of concentration, boredom, ineffective listening, and poor comprehension.

Most students who do not have a systematic approach to listening face difficulties in understanding a lecture, a seminar, or a discussion. They suffer from lack of concentration, boredom, ineffective listening, and poor comprehension. As one has to ensure high degree of understanding and remembrance, one should follow a systematic approach to listening. For example, an eminent scholar has to deliver a lecture on a topic relevant to a particular person's studies and career and he/she wants to listen to the professor. In order to take full advantage of this opportunity, he/she needs to follow a systematic listening method and apply appropriate listening strategies for better comprehension.

In order to improve your listening comprehension, some basic tips on good listening need to be followed and active listening techniques should be adopted. In addition, listening strategies should be developed for specific listening tasks such as lecture comprehension, two-way interactions, group interaction, student-teacher consultations, student-student negotiation, seminars, discussion sessions, and so on.

6.2.1 Ten Thumb Rules for Good Listening

Remember the 10 thumb rules for good listening that are listed in Table 6.1. These suggestions can help improve listening effectiveness.

TABLE 6.1 Rules of Good Listening

1.	Talking	x
2.	Thinking	x
3.	Distractions	x
4.	Mind wandering	x
5.	Putting the speaker at ease	✓
6.	Pre-judgement	x
7.	Patience	✓
8.	Being angry	x
9.	Empathising with the speaker	✓
10.	Taking notes	✓

Stop Talking

Do not talk while listening. One cannot be a speaker and a listener at the same time. The listener should accept his/her role and allow the speaker to talk. He/she should forget about his/her response to the listener and concentrate on the speaker's words.

Stop Thinking

It is not enough for the listener to keep his mouth shut while he/she is listening. He/she has to stop thinking too. He/she cannot listen effectively while thinking. He/she will not be able to focus 100% on what the speaker is telling.

Remove Distractions

In order to focus 100% on the person speaking, the listener should avoid all kinds of distractions. He/she should not create any distractions for himself/herself and should not allow others to interrupt.

Do Not Let Your Mind Wander

One of the main causes of listening inefficiency is the slowness of speech. We can listen faster than the speaker can speak. This lag time may make the listener's mind wander or daydream. This can be avoided by concentrating on each word spoken by the speaker.

Put Speaker at Ease

A conducive environment should be provided to the speaker in order to enable him/her to be at ease. If the speaker is not comfortable, he/she will not be able to speak clearly.

Do not Pre-judge

Give the speaker a chance to complete what he/she has to say. Pre-judgement closes the mind and does not allow you to perceive the speaker impartially. You can make proper judgement only after you have fully comprehended the information.

Be Patient

The speaker should be allowed sufficient time and not interrupted until he/she takes a pause and invites the listener to do so. Patience is the key to good listening. The listener may be in a hurry as he/she has to go somewhere or do something, but good listening demands that he/she listens to the speaker patiently.

Do not be Angry

The listener should control his/her temper while listening. He/she may not like what the speaker is telling, or may completely disagree with his/her point of view but good listening demands that he/she listens to him/her calmly without making any fuss.

Empathise with the Speaker

In order to understand the speaker's perspective and appreciate his/her point of view, the listener should try to put him/her in the speaker's position.

Take Notes

The listener should take notes if he/she wants to keep a record of what was said, and wants to use it at a later stage.

6.2.2 Active Listening Practices

Listening can be passive or active. Passive listening is the process of just absorbing the message encoded in the spoken word without any involvement. In passive listening, the listener plays no role. On the other hand, active listening is a dynamic, interactive communicative process in which the listener:

- Pays attention
- Shows interest in the speaker and speech
- Takes note of the speaker's body language
- Avoids distractions
- Responds non-verbally to encourage the speaker

As active listening is interactive and productive, it facilitates proper interaction and produces new understanding. It promotes more effective listener-speaker relationships, and helps us take advantage of opportunities we might miss by being a passive listener. That is why one needs to be an active listener rather than a passive one. Active listening requires conscious efforts on one's part and demands concentration, involvement and responsibility.

Passive listening is the process of just absorbing the message encoded in the spoken word without any involvement.

Active listening demands concentration, involvement, and responsibility.

In order to become an active listener, we have to adopt a set of listening practices that may help us understand the meaning of an oral message. Listed below are some guidelines to be followed by an active listener.

Attentive Listening

Unlike a passive listener, the active listener should show interest in the speaker and the speech. He/she should show desire to listen and be interested in what the speaker is telling. He/she should not show non-verbal signals such as audible snoring or rolling eyes that indicate that he/she does not want to listen. His/her posture must reflect his/her interest and his/her body language should indicate his/her keenness to listen.

An active listener would listen to the speaker patiently and carefully and be alert and pay attention while listening. Passive listeners generally listen to others in an unconscious manner without paying attention. By paying attention to both content as well as presentation, we can understand the speaker better.

Using Non-verbal Skills

Appropriate non-verbal skills may be used to indicate interest and understanding. Eye contact should be maintained with the speaker. The speaker should be helped and encouraged by positive body signals such as an occasional nod or a smile. The listener may also send non-verbal signals to indicate comprehension. He/she should also pay attention to the body language of the speaker in order to understand and interpret non-verbal clues for signs of stress, anxiety, excitement, enthusiasm, or boredom. This will help the listener analyse the verbal message in the right perspective.

Active listening includes using non-verbal skills, improving speaker's contribution, asking questions, making clarifications, and analysing an oral message.

Improving Speaker's Contribution

An active listener should take appropriate steps to improve the speaker's contribution. He/she should encourage the speaker to express his/her ideas clearly by indicating understanding and appreciation of his/her point of view.

Asking Questions

Asking questions forms an important part of the listening process as it leads to building up a good rapport between the speaker and the listener. By asking relevant questions we can get the maximum information from a speaker. Moreover, asking questions shows that one is listening and this encourages the speaker. The listener should not wait to be asked and must instead readily ask relevant clarifying questions.

He/she may ask open-ended or closed questions. Open-ended questions provide the speaker with an opportunity to elaborate a point whereas closed questions ask the speaker to be more exact and specific.

Open-ended questions provide the speaker with an opportunity to elaborate a point whereas closed questions ask the speaker to be more exact and specific.

Examples of Open-ended Questions

1. What are the advantages of this deal?
2. What is your personal opinion about the problem?
3. What do you think about this proposal?

Examples of Closed Questions

1. Is this deal acceptable to the management?
2. Are we facing this problem for the first time?
3. Will you accept this proposal?

While asking questions, the listener should not argue or be rigid on a question. The listener should have the liberty to handle the question the way he/she wants. Here are some tips on how to ask questions:

- Questions should be asked at the appropriate points. The speaker should not be interrupted.
- Questions should be chosen carefully. The purpose of asking a question should be to get clarifications and indicate comprehension.
- Simple language should be used to phrase questions.
- Questions should be asked one at a time.
- The listener should wait for an answer patiently.
- The listener should listen carefully to the answer and not jump to conclusions.

Clarifying

Clarify what the speaker is saying by paraphrasing what has been said or summarising one's understanding of the key points. This way the listener can show that he/she is listening carefully and paying attention.

Analysing

As an active listener, one should interpret and analyse what one hears in order to:

- Understand both explicit as well as implicit meaning of an oral message
- Differentiate between ideas, opinions, feelings, and facts, as expressed by the speaker
- Infer the meaning of unfamiliar words from contextual or internal clues
- Draw inferences and conclusions from the speech

6.2.3 Listening in Conversational Interaction

We may have to listen during two-way interactions that may include informal conversations, academic interactions, student-teacher consultations, student-student negotiation, job interviews, and so on. Listening plays a key role in these communicative situations as the output of listening in all these situations is to make considered oral responses. We need to develop effective listening strategies for these communicative situations.

The following suggestions can help improve listening effectiveness during face-to-face conversational interactions:

Listen for Conversational Signals

During a conversation, discussion, or other transaction involving more than one speaker, every participant has to take his/her turn at the appropriate moment. Many a time nobody is there to indicate this turn, or prompt or invite the participant to do so. Each participant has to look out for conversational signals indicating the possibility of starting his/her turn so that he/she is able to take a turn at the appropriate moment.

Listening in conversational interaction involves looking out for conversational signals, evaluating, labelling carefully, using attention signals, and adjusting the pace of listening.

Evaluate

While listening to professional and administrative requirements involving requests, suggestions or instructions, the listener should evaluate what he/she listens to in order to make a mental commentary and develop a line of thought. He/she has to determine necessary action as the output is to perform some physical activity, make an oral response, impart or solicit information, and so on.

Be Careful While Labelling

Whenever a listener hears someone for the first time, he/she starts forming impressions about him/her. These impressions about the background, nature, qualities, social standing, character of the speaker may be true or false. As these impressions lead to changes in the listener's behaviour towards the speaker, he/she should be careful while forming such impressions.

Use Attention Signals

In order to indicate that the listener is participating actively in a conversational interaction, he/she must use appropriate attention signals. These attention signals could be receptive expressions and utterances such as 'oh yes', 'yes', 'fine', 'of course', 'well', 'ok', 'that's fine', 'no problem', 'really', 'oh no', or just informal grunts such as 'uhuh's', 'mm's', 'un-hum', and so forth.

Adjust Your Pace of Listening

As mentioned before, the speed at which we listen is faster than the speed at which we can speak. This time lag may prove boring and lead to a lack of concentration, which may result in poor listening comprehension. So, we should adjust our pace of listening by reviewing what the speaker is saying during this lag time. Moreover, while the listener waits for the speaker's next idea, he/she should concentrate on the implications of what the speaker is talking about.

Work Hard at Listening

Most of us are really not good listeners. Thus, we have to work hard to become good listeners. Every chance to listen to someone provides us an opportunity to learn something. We must be actively involved in all communication and try to make every listening experience a memorable learning experience.

Progress Check 2

1. Which of the following is not an effective listening strategy for two-way interactions?

- (a) Labelling
- (b) Listening for conversational signals
- (c) Too many informal grunts
- (d) Making social judgements
- (e) Using attention signals
- (f) Carrying on mental commentary
- (g) Using receptive expressions and utterances
- (h) Increasing speed of listening

6.2.4 Listening to Structured Talks

In order to understand a structured talk (i.e., lectures, seminar talks, presentations, speeches, oral reports, and so on) or any other formal oral discourse, we require effective listening strategies that help us in comprehending the subject-content and language patterns of the oral message. These techniques include pre-listening analysis, predicting, use of background knowledge, intensive listening, and ability to understand the links between different parts of speech. In order to become an effective listener, we need to learn and polish these listening techniques.

Pre-listening Analysis

Pre-listening analysis includes determining the purpose of listening and knowing the speaker or presenter.

Determining the Purpose

The most important aspect of pre-listening analysis is determining what needs to be achieved by listening to the speaker. Does the listener want to listen to the speaker to get a broad understanding of a topic of his/her interest? Does he/she intend to obtain specific information? Does he/she want to be aware of the opinions and reactions of the speaker to a specific situation or problem? Does he/she want to understand specific instructions? Whether his/her purpose is to get facts or opinions, understand attitude or perspective, he/she must have a clear idea of what he/she wants to remember at the end of the conversation/talk/lecture/speech/presentation/seminar/workshop.

Listening to structured talks involves determining the purpose of listening, knowing the speaker, guessing the expected information, using background information and intensive listening techniques, and comprehending the logical links between different parts of presentation.

Knowing Your Speaker

The second essential aspect in pre-listening analysis is analysing the speaker. If the listener knows the speaker well, he/she will be able to make appropriate adaptations for better understanding. Is the speaker an expert of the subject, or just a generalist? What are his/her background and specific qualifications that make him/her fit for the presentation? Has the listener ever heard him/her before? Is he/she a native speaker? Answers to these questions will give the listener a fairly good idea of the speaker and help him/her improve.

Predicting

Predicting is a listening strategy for lecture comprehension. It is the process of guessing the information that one expects to receive during a lecture or talk. The listener should be able to think ahead, hypothesise, and predict.

Predicting includes various micro-skills, including the ability to:

- Guess the information that the lecture contains
- Use the title of the lecture/talk/presentation to roughly predict the central theme and the focus of the verbal message
- Scan the use of visual aids in the opening part of the lecture to predict the nature and scope of content
- Identify oral clues used by the speaker

Predicting is the process of guessing the information that one expects to receive during a lecture or talk.

The listener should try to guess the overall content of the speech, i.e. guessing the information that he/she expects to receive. The more he/she is familiar with the content, the more he/she understands the oral message. For example, if he/she is going to listen to a speech by the chief guest at the annual day programme of his/her college, the listener may ask himself/herself the following questions:

1. What is he going to talk about?
2. Is he going to talk about our college?
3. Is he going to tell something that I already know?
4. Is he going to talk about the growth of the college?
5. How long is he going to talk?
6. Will he give academic suggestions to the students of the college?
7. Will he ask questions?

The listener should also develop a positive attitude to the speaker and the topic.

Answers to such questions will help develop the required interest and motivation that are essential for effective listening. The listener should also develop a positive attitude to the speaker and the topic.

Using Background Knowledge

Once the listener has guessed the information that he/she is likely to receive, he/she may recall related information. He/she can pool his/her 'background knowledge' to get a general idea of what he/she is going to listen to. A familiar topic will make him/her more interested in the talk and he/she will actively listen to it, resulting in total comprehension. For example, when going to listen to a lecture on "Information Technology and Communication" if one is using one's background knowledge about information technology, one would find it easy to understand the lecture. Even if the speaker introduces new ideas and concepts, one may not find them too difficult. Moreover, the whole exercise of using background information will provide the necessary motivation essential for an active listener.

Once the listener has guessed the information that he/she is likely to receive, he/she may recall related information.

Intensive Listening

Once the listener has determined his/her purpose, analysed his/her speaker, and used prediction techniques and background knowledge, he/she is ready to listen to the lecture or talk. Most speakers organise the talk into three segments: introduction, body, and conclusion. The listener has to concentrate on each segment to understand the overall meaning, focus, and implication of the talk. The guidelines for this have been given below:

Most speakers organise a talk into three segments: introduction, body, and conclusion.

Listening to the Introduction

- Listen to the opening or introduction of the talk to get answers to the following questions:
 - (a) What is the position, knowledge, background, experience of the speaker?
 - (b) What is his/her credibility?
 - (c) What is the overall purpose of the talk?
 - (d) What is the central idea or theme?
 - (e) What is the overall organisational structure?

- (f) What does the speaker intend to do? (describe, instruct, report, narrate, explain, argue, persuade, illustrate, and so on)
- (g) What are the main points of the talk?
- Concentrate on the visual aids, if used by the speaker.
- Identify the key words or phrases that the speaker might use to emphasise the main points.

Listening to the Body

- As the body of a talk or lecture contains the main message, you should pay attention to every part of the body carefully.
- Concentrate on the verbal signposts in order to recognise the organisation and main points of the oral message.
- Recognise main supporting details of the oral message.
- Concentrate on visual aids such as overhead transparencies, flipcharts, handouts, slides, multimedia visuals, and so on to get a clear idea of the important points of the talk.

Listening to the Conclusion

- Listen to the closing or conclusion of the talk to understand the main themes of the verbal message.
- Recognise the speaker's focus of the talk.
- Concentrate on what the speaker wants the listeners to do, or remember.

Understanding the Links between Different Parts of Speech

The most important aspect of lecture comprehension is identifying the key points of a lecture. In order to recognise key points, we have to understand the links between different parts of speech. This involves recognising listening cues used by the speaker. Every speaker uses various techniques to indicate the relative importance of different parts of information contained in the talk. These techniques include identifying prosodic and syntactic features, oral discourse markers, and transitions.

Every speaker uses various techniques to indicate the relative importance of different parts of information contained in the talk.

Prosodic Features and Syntactic Features

Prosodic features include pauses, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns.

Prosodic features include pauses, stress, intonation, and rhythm patterns. A listener needs a proper understanding of English pronunciation and articulation in order to understand these features. The chapter on "Oral Communication and Speaking Techniques" in Part Three of this book contains a detailed discussion on these topics.

Syntactic features comprise grammatical structures such as subordinate clauses, noun complements, and so on. Comprehending these syntactic structures during listening demands a fairly good understanding of English grammar. Listeners should concentrate on these features to get the correct meaning of the message.

Syntactic features comprise grammatical structures such as subordinate clauses, noun complements, and so on.

Oral Discourse Markers

Oral discourse markers include signal phrases, logical connectors, and transitional signals.

Signal Phrases

Lecturers and speakers use specific words and phrases to indicate major transitions and emphasis in their lectures. As illustrated in Table 6.2, they help the listener understand the links between different parts of the talk.

Lecturers and speakers use specific words and phrases to indicate major transitions and emphasis in their lectures.

TABLE 6.2 Signal Phrases

Purpose of the Speaker	Signal Phrases
Introducing a topic	Today, I'd like to talk about..., What I'm going to discuss is..., The main point of the discussion today is..., To begin with..., In the first place..., My first point is ..., At the start let me say that..., First I'd like to discuss..., Today I'd like to describe...
Developing an idea	If we critically examine the situation..., As you know that..., The most significant point is..., The best solution to the problem is..., It is significant to note that..., Let's try to understand it..., It's very interesting to note..., This means that..., As you are aware..., The crucial factor is..., The point to note is,
Emphasising a point	I am sure you'll agree with me..., No one can deny the fact that..., I'd like to emphasise..., The next point is crucial to my argument...
Contrasting several ideas	In contrast, On the other hand..., If we make a comparative analysis..., On the contrary.
Showing transition of ideas	The next important point is..., The second significant aspect is..., Let's consider another factor ..., My next point is...
Concluding	Finally; At the end..., That's all I wanted to discuss..., I'd like to sum up..., I'd like to conclude..., In conclusion...

Logical Connectors and Transitional Signals

As illustrated in Table 6.3, speakers use logical connectors to show logical organisation and rhetorical features of a talk.

TABLE 6.3 Logical Connectors and Transitional Signals

Purpose of the Speaker	Logical Connectors and Transitional Signals
Adding a point	Moreover, In addition, Next, Then, Furthermore, Second, Finally
Comparing	Similarly, Likewise, In the same way
Making a contrast	In contrast, By comparison, In comparison, However, Nevertheless, If we make a comparative analysis
Showing segmentation	Right, OK, Well, All right, And, Now, That's fine, That's all, etc.
Exemplifying	In other words, For example, For instance, Take for example
Temporal	Eventually, At that time, For the time being, As, After, Before, Since, Till, Until, When, As soon as, By the time
Explaining/Showing cause and effect	Therefore, Thus, So, That is why, As, Because, Hence, For that reason, As a result, As a consequence, Consequently
Showing emphasis	Obviously, As you can see, Infact, As you know, Actually, Naturally, Of course, You see

Other Transitions

Apart from oral discourse markers, speakers might use several other transitions to lead listeners from one idea to another. The following are some such transitions:

- **Visual transitions:** Some speakers may add a visual between regular visual aids in order to give a “visual” transition. Such visuals might be an important clue to understand that part of the talk or presentation.
- **Repetitions:** Speakers may use the same words, phrases, or ideas twice to initiate a transition.
- **Questions:** Speakers may ask a question to make a transition.
- **Sequence:** A speaker may use sequence or point-by-point description to indicate transition (for example, There are two important considerations...The first one is.. The second one is).
- **Flashback:** A speaker may use a flashback technique to start a new point (for example, Do you recall my first observation).
- **Pauses:** Some speakers effectively use pausing as a transition technique because they give the listeners time to think.

Progress Check 3

1. Which of the following is not an effective listening strategy for lecture comprehension?

- (a) Audience analysis
- (b) Predicting
- (c) Use of background knowledge
- (d) Recognising key phrases
- (e) Concentrating on speaker's appearance
- (f) Understanding the visual aids
- (g) Recognising minor points of the oral message
- (h) Analysing the situation
- (i) Speaker analysis
- (j) Understanding all the illustrations
- (k) Identifying the key points of a lecture
- (l) Concentrating on the verbal signposts in order to recognise the organisation
- (m) Determining the purpose of listening
- (n) Recognising the focus of the talk
- (o) Understanding the links between different parts of speech
- (p) Recognising listening cues

6.2.5 Team Listening

In view of the widespread use of oral communication in team management and decision making, there can be little doubt about the value of good listening skills in achieving group communicative goals. When we take part in a group communicative situation, we cannot contribute to the stated purposes of the communication unless we are listening properly. By participating as an active listener, we may meet a personal need to contribute to the accomplishments of the goals of a group activity. Moreover, active participation as a listener in a group and its discussions and deliberations serves the group-centered needs of an individual. Finally, active listening meets the ego-centered needs of listeners by enhancing their status as successful “communicators”.

Listening in teams is more difficult than listening to structured talks and well-organised lectures. While we listen to a talk, we get information in an organised and structured form. Understanding the main points is not difficult because the speaker may repeat them several times during the talk. The use of signposts and visual aids also make comprehension easier. On the other hand, when we listen to deliberations during a group discussion, meeting, or team interactions, we get information in a disorganised and unclear form. There are no repetitions of points, no visual aids to clarify points and improve comprehension, no verbal signposts to indicate organisation and main points in an oral message. It is, therefore, important that we take extra precautions during team listening.

The following suggestions are designed to help improve team listening skills.

Active listening meets the ego-centered needs of listeners by enhancing their status as successful "communicators". Listening in teams is more difficult than listening to structured talks and well-organised lectures.

Avoid Distractions

There are two kinds of distractions that might disrupt the listening process—surrounding noise and physical disturbances, and disturbed state of mind.

There are two kinds of distractions that might disrupt the listening process. The first of these distractions result from surrounding noise and physical disturbances. In order to avoid these external distractions during the process of listening, you have to ensure that all channels are free of noise during the time of communication. The second type of distractions may result from your disturbed state of mind. The best way to control these distractions is to avoid team listening while you are emotionally disturbed. However, if you cannot avoid listening, you should focus 100% on what other members of the team are talking about.

Avoid Negative Non-verbal Signals

Using negative non-verbal signals during group communication is not only rude but also against team spirit as it may lead to misunderstanding and mistrust between team members. Do not use non-verbal signals to show disagreement, boredom, and lack of comprehension. It is better to express these feelings verbally. Avoid using fingers or negative head shaking to say 'no', or 'rolling eyes' to indicate that the speaker is a fool, or negative hand gestures to show that you disagree.

Do not use non-verbal signals to show disagreement, boredom, and lack of comprehension.

It is impolite to interrupt a person who is speaking as it shows lack of respect and creates misunderstanding.

Don't Interrupt

It is impolite to interrupt a person who is speaking as it shows lack of respect and creates misunderstanding. You may have something important to say or may be very eager to give a quick reply or opinion but it is not fair to interrupt the speaker. It makes you overeager and careless. Good team spirit demands better manners.

Be Involved

In order to be an effective team listener, do not just absorb the message encoded in the spoken word without any involvement but be alert and pay close attention while listening to your team members. Make conscious efforts with concentration, involvement and responsibility to improve your listening effectiveness as a team member.

Make conscious efforts with concentration, involvement and responsibility to improve your listening effectiveness as a team member.

Recognise Important Facts

It is important to recognize important facts during team listening because team members might express them informally, in a casual manner. You have to obtain relevant information and identify the main ideas and supporting details. Although you have to listen carefully to everything that your team members say, you need to filter the information to identify the overall purpose, the central theme and the main focus of what they are saying.

It is important to recognize important facts during team listening because team members might express them informally in a casual manner.

Good team members avoid making subjective observations while listening to each other and avoid giving judgements on what they listen.

Be Objective

Good team members avoid making subjective observations while listening to each other. Being objective will help you as well as the team members in getting a clear picture of each other's ideas and feelings. Also, avoid giving judgements on what you listen. Expressions such as "I think your reasoning is inappropriate", or "I do not understand your attitude" are judgmental and should be avoided.

Make Notes

Make notes to retain and use the information that you receive during team listening. Do not rely on your memory. Refer to the next section for learning effective note taking techniques.

Progress Check 4

1. Which of the following listening practices will make you a better team listener?

- (a) Using negative non-verbal signals
- (b) Controlling external and internal distractions
- (c) Becoming actively involved
- (d) Listening between the lines
- (e) Interrupting
- (f) Asking questions
- (g) Rephrasing
- (h) Taking notes
- (i) Being subjective
- (j) Relaxing during lag time

6.2.6 Listening and Note Taking

While listening to a lecture or a talk, or to a team member during a group discussion or meeting, one needs to remember the information so that it can be used in some other form. It is better not to trust only one's memory, and one should take notes while listening. Taking notes helps one to understand the points clearly and keep a record for future reference. Even if the facts are easy to remember, they should be jotted down for clarity.

Note taking may be defined as the process of writing down quickly, briefly, and clearly the important points of a lecture, speech, presentation, or any structured verbal message. It involves summarising and paraphrasing the verbal message.

Techniques of Note Taking

Taking notes while listening to lectures and talks is an important academic activity. Learning effective note-taking techniques is essential because it is more challenging than making reading notes. While reading a text, you can reread several times for better comprehension and notes can be made leisurely. However, this is not possible in note taking because the speaker is not going to repeat his/her points for your convenience.

The four steps of note taking include listening, filtering, paraphrasing, and noting.

It is important that you avoid writing down everything you hear. You have to carefully filter the information that you receive and adopt a strategy that enables you to understand the lecture quickly and make appropriate notes. Effective note-taking strategies are essential. Note taking includes four simple steps, i.e., listening, filtering, paraphrasing, and noting.

Listen

- Follow the 10 thumb rules for good listening and apply active listening techniques for better comprehension.
- Carefully listen to the verbal message in order to identify its purpose and scope.
- Identify different modes and styles of delivery (i.e., reading style, conversational style, informal style, rhetorical style, and so on).
- Deduce meanings of words and phrases from their context and infer relationships.
- Recognise key terms related to the subject/topic of the lecture.
- Recognise function of stress and intonation to signal information structure.
- Recognise function of non-verbal cues as markers of emphasis and attitude.
- Interpret the oral message with reference to oral conventions followed by the speaker.

Filter

- Do not try to write everything.
- Filter the information received.
- Concentrate on verbal signposts to recognise the organisation and main points in an oral message.
- Identify relationships among units within the speech (i.e., main points, supporting points, minor points, generalisations, hypotheses, illustrations, and so on).
- Look out for key phrases and signal words.
- Identify the role of discourse markers.
- Identify the main points.

Paraphrase

- After identifying the core information, rephrase suitably.
- Use appropriate words and phrases to express the central idea, main points, and main supporting details.
- Do not use full sentences.

Note

- After restructuring and rephrasing the core information, jot them down.
- Use appropriate reduction techniques such as abbreviations and symbols to save time.
- Use subordinating techniques and a suitable method of sequencing, i.e. numerals and numbers, decimalisation, and so on.
- Use note cards or notebooks to record notes.

Progress Check 5

1. Study the following statements about note making, and mark True or False against each of them.
 - (a) Note taking refers to the process of making reading notes.
 - (b) Note taking does not involve paraphrasing.
 - (c) The act of decoding in note taking involves recognition of false starts, pauses, intonation, and rhythm patterns.
 - (d) While taking notes, the listener should write everything that he/she hears in the lecture.
 - (e) The listener must adopt a careful strategy that enables him/her to understand the lecture.
 - (f) Every speaker follows certain oral conventions.
 - (g) Identifying key points of a lecture does not involve recognising signal words and phrases.
 - (h) Lecturers and speakers never try to indicate major transitions in their lectures.

Exercise

1. Answer the following questions:
 - (a) What is listening comprehension?
 - (b) Discuss some positive listening practices.
 - (c) Differentiate between active and passive listening.
 - (d) What are the different strategies for lecture comprehension?
 - (e) What are the factors that make an effective team listener?
 - (f) What is the process of taking notes while listening?
2. Listen to the radio for half an hour. Evaluate and scan the information that you receive for topics of interest to you. Match topics against your own interest and make mental notes. Write a summary of what you have listened after one hour.
3. Listen to the weather report on television. Concentrate on the weather forecast about your area in order to decide appropriate clothes to wear during the day.
4. Listen to a panel discussion on television. Listen to what the speakers are saying, also how they are saying it (for example, is he or she surprised, annoyed, angry, upset, confused, relaxed, tense, pleased, confident, nervous, and so on). Prepare a brief report on the discussion mentioning the important points of discussion.
5. Listen to a 30-minute television news report. Use the listening techniques discussed in this chapter. Then, write a summary of the news highlighting significant events, incidents, and persons in the news.